reports include annual reports of companies and organisations, technical reports, project reports, thesis, and so on.

A non-formal report, on the other hand, could be a brief account of a specific business or professional activity. It is usually written to provide introductory information about a routine affair. Non-formal reports are usually short and do not need elaborate descriptions and discussions. As the content is generally insufficient for a formal report, an informal report may involve the use of printed forms, letter formats, or memo formats. Although non-formal reports are usually routine, they may be either informational or analytical and may use the oral or written form. Examples of non-formal reports include laboratory reports, daily production reports, trip reports, and so forth.

An informal report may involve the use of printed forms, letter formats, or memo formats.

Progress Check 1

1. **Which of the following statements are not True in the light of the above discussion about the nature, significance, and types of reports?**
   (a) Executive decisions in the professional world may be based on reports.
   (b) Non-formal reports may be written in letter or memorandum form.
   (c) Professionals do not have to write analytical reports.
   (d) A report is a formal document written for a specific audience to meet a specific need.
   (e) Reports never reinforce, prompt, motivate, or persuade readers to act.
   (f) An analytical report presents facts of a case, problems, conditions, or situations without any analysis, interpretations, or recommendations.
   (g) The most important purpose of a report is to help in the analysis of a condition, situation, or a problem for an effective solution.
   (h) Reports never record events and happenings.
   (i) Routine reports are prepared and presented to convey special information related to a single condition, situation, problem, or occasion.
   (j) Formal reports are generally shorter than non-formal reports.
2. **Study the following table and match different descriptions of reports (left column) with appropriate types of reports (right column):**

Different descriptions of reports	*Types of reports*
1. Lengthy reports	(a) Informational
2. Presentation of routine information	(b) Analytical
3. Data on periodic and situational activities without analysis	(c) Routine
4. Short reports	(d) Special
5. Presentation of specific information	(e) Formal
6. Analysis of data to persuade readers	(f) Non-formal

26.2 WRITING EFFECTIVE REPORTS

26.2.1 Report Formats

As listed in Table 26.2, there are four common formats of reports, that is, printed forms, letter format, memo format, and manuscript format. The choice of format can be made according to the nature, length, scope, and function of the report, and type of audience.

TABLE 26.2 Formats of Reports

Format	*Description*
Printed forms	Forms prepared to record for repetitive and routine data
Letter format	Short informal reports to be communicated to someone outside an organisation
Memo format	Short informal reports to be communicated to someone within an organisation
Manuscript format	Formal reports printed on plain paper

Printed Forms

Printed forms are generally used to collect routine information. For example, a company may keep printed forms for recording daily production or monthly sales. Similarly, an organisation may use printed forms for trip reports, conference reports, laboratory reports, inspection reports, confidential performance reports, and so on. Using a printed form is quite simple because the person filling it is just required to fill in the blanks, or tick against the listed items. Detailed descriptions or discussions need not be provided.

There are three main advantages of using printed forms for reporting. Firstly, they are systematic and make for easy reading. The readers can easily locate and identify important information. Secondly, they are more objective and factual with little scope for the writer to be subjective about the content. There is no subjective interpretation of the material used in the report. Facts are recorded quite objectively. Finally, they save time. It is less time consuming to prepare a report in printed form than preparing reports in other formats. Figure 26.1 gives an example of a report in printed form.

Printed forms are more objective and factual with little scope for the writer to be subjective about the content.

TOUR REPORT
Report on Participation in Professional Conference

Office order No. 14789/2015 dated 04-01-2015

Name of the officer:	Kumar Abhishek
Designation:	Senior Marketing Manager
Address:	Regional Office, Syndicate Consultancy Services Pvt. Ltd. Nayadeep, Andheri (W), Mumbai-53
Name of the conference:	Emerging Concepts in Sales and Marketing
Name of the Organiser:	Indian Management Association
Place of Conference:	Hotel Tajmahal, Mumbai
Duration of Conference:	January 14 – January 18, 2015
Organisation of Conference:	
(a) Sponsors of the Conference:	1. Tata Consultancy Services 2. Air Sahara 3. Reliance Industries 4. Indian Airlines
(b) Number of Participating companies:	25
(c) Number of sessions:	12
(d) Number of presentations:	32

Date: 27th January, 2015
Signature: Kumar Abhishek

Fig. 26.1 Printed Form

Letter Format

The letter format may be used for short reports that have to be communicated to someone outside an organisation. A letter format contains all the elements of a letter along with some additional sections such as illustrations, references, and so on. Headings may be used in a letter report. The letter format may be used for informational, analytical, routine, special, or non-formal reports. For example, there is an accident on the shop floor in a company and report has to be sent to the insurance company. Other examples of the letter format include evaluation reports, feasibility reports, survey reports, legal reports, and so on. Figure 26.2 shows an example.

The letter format may be used for informational, analytical, routine, special, or non-formal reports.

ALPHA CONSULTANCY PVT. LTD.
C-21/12, Ring Road, Delhi-110 052
www.alphagroup.com

January 31, 2015

Mr G Ravi Kiran
Chief Safety Officer
NDP Limited, NDPL Building
37-D, Jawaharlal Nehru Road, Kolkata-700 071

SUBJECT: MINE INSPECTION REPORT

Dear Mr Ravi Kiran:

The Alpha Consultancy team inspected the AP section of the IV Seam in NDP Colliery to collect various parameters to determine the Rock Mass Rating (RMR) of the roof. A detailed description regarding different locations visited is given below:

Location A: Shaft Level East I (Rise)

Roof rocks were exposed at this place upto a height of 3 meter by blasting to study the rock types and layer thickness. Three rider seams of thickness varying from 3.5 to 4 centimeter are observed at different horizons. Samples were collected for petrographical study.

1. **Litho types**
   Major litho types observed in sequence were sandy shale, shaly sandstone, sandstone, and grey sandstone. The rider seam 1 (3.5 centimeter thick) occurs in between sandy shale and shaly sandstone. Rider seam 2 (4 centimeter thick) is found between shaly sandstone and sandstone. Rider seam 3 (4 centimeter thick) is observed between sandy shale and grey sandstone. The presence of rider seams in between relatively competent beds is a point of concern from the point of view of the stability.
2. **Joints**
   Three sets of joints were observed. Vertical joints were observed in the roof rocks with a joint intensity of 2.5 numbers per metre length and another joint set spacing was found to be about 4 numbers per metre length. The third joint was found to be oblique to the earlier joint sets. It was also observed that the coal seam just below the roof was well cleated bituminous coal.
3. **Other Structural features**
   A dyke having thickness of 4.5 meter was observed running from North to South throughout the property. Slickensides were seen close to the dyke. Minor slips were also observed.
4. **Water seepage**
   No water seepage was noticed and the roof was completely dry.

(*Contd.*)

Location B: Shaft Level East II (Rise)

Roof fall upto the horizon of rider seam 3 was observed. This fall might have been caused as a result of water seepage (which was at the rate of about 20 ml/min at the time of investigation). Supports were provided at the middle of the gallery with a width of the gallery being 4.6 meter. The location under investigation was proposed to be the haulage point. Roof drilling using electric drills for bolting was attempted in the beginning and it was found that drilling the sandstone roof was difficult due to excess wear and tear of the bit. Thus, roof bolting could not be done.

Location C: Shaft Level East III (Rise)

A fault with a downward throw of 2.5 was seen. Slickensides were seen nearer to the fault upto a length of 5 meter.

Location D: 1 E Dip (North to South)

Upon general inspection of the dip gallery, of width varying from 4 to 4.6 m, it was found that the gallery was stable. Only at some places (gallery and junctions) pit props were provided at the centre of the gallery. No water seepage was seen.

Location E: 2 E Dip /2 L

This is the haulage level with steel pit prop supports placed at 2.2 metre centre to centre.

Location F: 6 D/2 E Level

Face blasting was carried out at this location.

Location G: 2 L

Side fall was observed in the level gallery.

Location H: 2 EL/ID

The galleries are six months old and the roof was found to be dry and intact.

Location I: IR/10 EL near Main Dip

Gallery width is only 4 meter and water seepage from the roof was around 20 ml/min.

Location J: 10LW/ID near Main Dip

Slips were found.

Location K: 7 LW/IR

Junction was observed for its stability. It was found that the roof was intact with a single wooden prop at the centre.

Location L: Drift from IV to V seam

A downthrow fault was observed. The roof rocks were studied for RMR determination. The roof was found to be dry.

The inspection team included Dr Suresh Patra, Dr Seema Biswas, Mr Animesh Kumar and Mr Mohan Srivastava, all senior consultants at Alpha Consultancy.

We at Alpha Consultancy believe that the findings of the team will help you go ahead with your plan to modernise the support system with permanent roadways.

Sincerely,

Sd/-
A P Khemka
General Manager

Fig. 26.2 Letter Format

Memo Format

The memo format can be used for short reports that have to be communicated within an organization. A memo format should contain all the elements of a standard memo. In addition, it may contain a few extra sections. Like a report in the letter form, a memo report should contain headings for easy reading and reference. The memo format may be used for all types of reports, that is, informational, analytical, routine, special, or non-formal. An example has been given in Fig. 26.3.

The memo format may be used for all types of reports, that is, informational, analytical, routine, special, or non-formal.

Innova Solutions Pvt Ltd
Interoffice Memorandum

Date: February 3, 2015

To: Ms. Kavita Kashayap
Director (Sales)

From: Afsar Ali Haider
Chief Training Manager

Subject: INTER- ISPL MEET ON TELEMARKETING STRATEGIES – A

REPORT

Sales managers from all 24 Regional offices of ISPL in India got together between 15 – 20th January 2015, to share their experiences of the use and effectiveness of telemarketing strategies (TMS) in India and to discuss the future plan of action of ISPL in India. There were sessions on Sales Training courses run in the ISPL Regional offices and the activities of the training centres at various parts of India. Sessions were also conducted on TMS materials produced in different ISPL training centres in India and each representative participant received sets of materials produced by the Corporate training centre in Mumbai.

Eminent sales trainers like Mr Anup Khandelwal, Dr N K Das, Ms Savitha Kumar, Coordinator ISPL TMS Scheme, and Mr Naveen Goswami, Coordinator, ISPL Training Centre Scheme, enlightened the participants through their speech and subsequent workshops. The workshops were highly interactive, and the participants actively participated in the deliberations. The question-answer sessions were particularly very interesting. The level of interest and commitment of the participants was remarkable. The meet was very enlightening and successful.

Recommendations

- Many such interactive meetings are necessary to enliven our capacity as sales promoters and to find some tentatvie solutions to some of the common problems that ISPL sales managers in India face.
- The Corporate Training Centre in Mumbai should be asked to produce similar TMS materials for sales trainees of ISPL.
- A few seminars and workshops on telemarketing strategies should be organised by the regional offices.

Fig. 26.3 Memo Format

Manuscript Format

The manuscript format can be used for long and formal reports. These reports are divided into sections and sub-sections, each with a clear heading. These headings and sub-headings are organised in a logical sequence. While preparing a report in manuscript form, the writer needs to be careful about its structure and elements. A structured report will help in thinking clearly and deciding where to put each fact or idea. It also makes reading easy and helps the readers find the information they need. The manuscript format is discussed in detail in the next section.

The manuscript format can be used for long and formal reports.

Progress Check 2

1. **Which of the four formats of reports would be the most appropriate for each of the following?**
   (a) Annual report of a research organisation
   (b) A report on the progress of a research project
   (c) Daily production report of a lift manufacturing company
   (d) A research report
   (e) A product launch report to be written by the marketing manager of a company for the marketing director of the company.
   (f) Monthly sales report of a pharmaceutical company
   (g) A report on the feasibility of launching a new product
   (h) A short report examining the problem of poor sales of a new product

26.2.2 Structure of Formal Reports

When writing a formal report, the choice of format as well the parts of the report must be carefully planned. Although the circumstances in which a report is written may determine its structure, the content of the report has to be organised in a logical way to help the readers understand the message clearly.

Formal reports are divided into many components for clarity.

Parts of a Report

A formal report may include the following parts or elements:

1. Title page
2. Preface
3. Letter of Transmittal
4. Acknowledgements
5. Table of Contents
6. List of Illustrations
7. Abstract/Executive summary
8. Introduction
9. Methodology
10. Discussion/Finding/Analysis
11. Conclusion

12. Recommendation
13. Appendices
14. References and Bibliography

Each of these parts of a formal report will now be discussed in detail.

Title Page

A formal report usually begins with a title page. It contains the title of the report, the name of the person or organisation to whom the report is being submitted, the name of the report writer/s, and the date. A Sample Title Page is given in Fig. 26.4.

Title Page

A REPORT ON

Improving Blast Efficiency Through
Performance Analysis

SUBMITTED TO

Department of Science and Technology
Government of India

SUBMITTED BY

Rakesh Kumar
Research Scholar, IIT, New Delhi

DATE

August 16, 2014

Fig. 26.4 Sample Title Page

Preface

The preface is an optional element in a formal report. It introduces the report by mentioning its salient features and scope.

Letter of Transmittal

The transmittal letter is a brief covering letter from the report writer explaining the causes for writing the report. It may contain the objectives, scope, and other highlights of the report. It may also contain acknowledgements if the report does not include an acknowledgement section. Figure 26.5 shows the format of a Transmittal letter.

The transmittal letter is a brief covering letter from the report writer explaining the causes for writing the report.

Date

Dear .....,

_____

_____

_____

_____

Signature

Fig. 26.5 Format of Transmittal Letter

Acknowledgement

The acknowledgement section contains the names of persons who contributed to the production of the report and made the report possible. It is just a 'thank you note'.

Table of Contents

The 'table of contents' provides the reader an overall view of the report and shows its organisation.

This section lists the main headings and the subheadings in the report with page numbers. Figure 26.6 contains a Sample Table of Contents.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Preface		1
Acknowledgement		2
List of illustrations		3
Abstract		4
1. Introduction	6	
2. Methodology	9	
3. Discussion	10	
4. Conclusion	15	
5. Recommendations 19		
Appendices		20
References		28

Fig. 26.6 Sample Table of Contents

List of Illustrations

The 'list of illustrations' gives systematic information about tables, graphs, figures, and charts used in the report. List of illustrations is usually included if the number of these illustrations are more than ten. Figure 26.7 contains a Sample List of Illustrations.

List of Illustrations is usually included if the number of these illustrations are more than ten.

LIST OF ILLUSTRATIONS

	Tables	
Table 1	———————	1
Table 2	———————	8
Table 3	———————	12
Table 4	———————	14
	Figures	
Figure 1	———————	3
Figure 2	———————	9
Figure 3	———————	22

Fig. 26.7 Sample List of Illustrations

Abstract or Executive Summary

An abstract or an executive summary summarises the essential information in the report, focussing on key facts, findings, observations, results, conclusions, and recommendations.

Introduction

This section introduces the readers to the report and prepares them for the discussion that follows by providing background information, defining its aims and objectives, and discussing the scope and limitations of the report. It helps the readers in understanding and analysing the report as it includes facts that the reader must know in order to understand the discussion and the analysis that follow.

Methodology

While writing a report, information may have to be gathered from library and archival sources or through Internet surfing, interviews, surveys, and formal/informal discussions. The section on methodology summarises the methods of data collection, the procedures for investigating the situation/problem, and the criteria of survey.

Discussion/Description/Analysis

This is the main part of the report as it presents the data that has been collected in an organised form. It focuses on facts and findings of the report and may include an objective description and discussion of the problem, an analysis of the situation, and findings of the investigation. It is usually divided into sections and sub-sections with well-structured and clear headings and sub-headings.

Conclusions

This section conveys the significance and meaning of the report to readers by presenting a summary of the discussions and findings, results and conclusions, implications of the conclusions presented, and inferences.

Recommendations

This section contains recommendations that are based on results and conclusions. As they propose a course of action to improve a situation or a condition, they may present several ways to solve a problem or improve a situation. It may also indicate the need and nature for further work in the concerned area.

Appendices

An appendix contains supporting material or data, which is kept separate from the main body of the report to avoid interrupting the line of development of the report.

References and Bibliography

This section may contain references to books, journals, reports, dissertations, or/and published government documents, and other sources used in the report. It may also consist of a list of materials for further reference.

Progress Check 3

1. Study the following table and match different components of a formal report (right column) with their functions (left column):

Functions	*Components of a formal report*
1. Contains suggestions that are based on results and conclusions	(a) Preface
2. Conveys the significance and meaning of the report to readers by presenting a summary of discussions and findings	(b) Letter of Transmittal
3. Presents the data collected	(c) Acknowledgements
4. Summarises methods of data collection and the procedures for investigating the situation/problem, and the criteria of survey	(d) Executive summary
5. Provides background information, defines aims and objectives, and discusses the scope and limitations of the report	(e) Introduction
6. Summarises the essential information in the report	(f) Methodology
7. Contains the names of persons who contributed to the production of the report and made the report possible	(g) Discussion
8. Explains the causes for writing the report	(h) Conclusion
9. Introduces the report by mentioning its salient features and scope	(i) Recommendations

26.2.3 Writing Strategies

Whether one has to write a short informal report or a long formal report, one needs to adopt effective writing strategies. As reports are systematic attempts to discuss problems, situations, or conditions and stimulate thinking or action in individuals and groups, a systematic plan of writing should be followed.

The following steps will help in organising and presenting the report systematically.

Analyse the Problem and Purpose

The process of writing an effective report begins with an objective analysis of the problem that is to be discussed and the objectives of writing the report. In other words, the following two questions need to be answered before beginning to write a report:

1. What do you want to present or discuss in the report?
2. Why do you want to present it?

The process of writing an effective report begins with an objective analysis of the problem that is to be discussed and the objectives of writing the report.

Answers to these questions will help in identifying the problem that led to the writing of the report and determining the purpose of the report. The problem may be written down in the form of a statement. Expressing the problem in words will provide clarity of purpose and help in writing the report systematically.

Identifying the specific purpose of a report involves identifying an observable measurable action that the readers would do after reading the report.

Defining the purpose of the report will give it direction and make it focused. Identifying the specific purpose of a report involves identifying an observable measurable action that the readers would take after reading the report. The writer's purpose should be to match the audience's needs, knowledge, expectations, and interests. It should focus on audience behaviour and restate the theme of the report.

Determine the Scope of the Report

In order to keep the report precise and to the point, the amount of information gathered should be limited to the most essential and important facts. It is important to define a reasonable scope of the report. By determining the scope of the report, the writer will be able to decide what should be covered in it, and gather appropriate background information and supporting data. The scope of the report should be narrowed down and made specific so that a reasonable length is maintained.

Determine the Needs of the Audience

When a report is being planned, the writer should know who will eventually read it. A report will be effective only if the writer is able to connect his/her purpose with the interests and needs of his/her readers. When planning a report, the writer should think from his/her readers' perspective. He/she should avoid making false assumptions about his/her readers and should strive to be practical and rational. The following questions are relevant in this context.

When planning a report, the writer should think from his/her readers' perspective.

- Who is the audience? (age, education, subject knowledge, professional affiliation, status, preferences, biases, attitudes, interests, language level, and so on.)
- How is the report relevant to the audience?
- What is in it for the audience?
- What does the audience expect from the report?
- How much background information will the audience need?

Answers to these questions will provide essential information about the readers that will help the writer to make important decisions about the content, the nature of information that he/she needs, and the level of language that he/she should use in his/her report.

Gather All the Information

It is important to ensure that the information is accurate, bias free, current, and relevant.

Once the problem and purpose has been analysed, the scope is defined, and the audience has been analysed, the writer is ready to gather information. As he/she knows what he/she is looking for, he/she may not find it very difficult to gather information. He/she may gather information through primary sources (discussions, interviews, observation, surveys, questionnaires, experiments, and so on) or secondary sources (Internet, reports, books, journals, dissertations, magazines, pamphlets, newspapers, and so on). However, it is important to ensure that the information is accurate, bias free, current, and relevant.

Analyse and Organise the Information

Before actually organising the information, an outline may be prepared by choosing the central idea, main ideas, the major supporting ideas, and developing the details.

Once the information has been gathered, the report writer needs to analyse and organise it. Analysis of information involves evaluating the information objectively, making comparative analyses of different sets of information for obtaining new ideas, and interpreting facts and figures for their relative importance. Organising the information involves using an appropriate logical pattern to arrange the information in the report (Refer to Chapter 4). Before actually organising the information, an outline may be prepared by choosing the central idea, main ideas, the major supporting ideas, and developing the details.

Writing the First Draft

Once the outline has been prepared and the organisational pattern of the report has been decided, the first working draft can be written. While writing the first draft, the following points must be remembered:

- Focus on the scope and purpose of the report.
- Simple and direct language should be used.

Reviewing and Revising

Once the rough draft of the report has been written, it should be reviewed, edited, and revised in order to improve the quality of its content and presentation. Reviewing is the process of analysing whether the report achieved its purpose, whereas editing involves correcting its format, style, grammar, spelling, and punctuation. Revision focuses on improving the content and language of the report.

Writing the Final Draft

Once the rough draft of the report reviewed and revised, the final draft can be composed. When writing the final draft, the following points should be taken care of:

- The report should be simple, clear, concise, direct, and readable.
- Appropriate words, sentences and meaningful paragraphs should be used.
- Appropriate linking devices should be used.
- Graphic highlighting techniques to improve readability and comprehension should be applied.
- Important points should be emphasised.

Exercise

1. **Write brief notes on the following:**
   (a) Significance of reports
   (b) Informational and analytical reports
   (c) Routine and special reports
   (d) Oral and written reports
   (e) Formal and non-formal reports
2. **Identify the format that you will use in the following kinds of reports:**
   (a) Accident report of a company to be submitted to the police
   (b) Annual report of a multinational company
   (c) Weekly production report
   (d) Monthly visit report
   (e) Trip report of a company executive
   (f) A company report examining a problem and its solutions
   (g) A report on benefits of computerisation in railways
   (h) Performance report
   (i) Recruitment report
   (j) Progress report of a construction project
   (k) A research report
3. **Discuss the various elements of a formal report.**
4. **Discuss each of the following steps of report writing process in one paragraph.**

(a) Analysis of the problem and purpose
(b) Determination of the scope of a report
(c) Audience analysis in report writing
(d) Data collection in report writing
(e) Organisation of information
(f) Writing the first draft
(g) Review and revision

Key to Progress Check

Progress Check 1

1. (c), (e), (f), (h), (i), (j)
2. 1e, 2c, 3a, 4f, 5d, 6b

Progress Check 2

1. (a) Manuscript format
   (b) Manuscript format
   (c) Printed form
   (d) Manuscript format
   (e) Memo format
   (f) Printed form
   (g) Memo format
   (h) Memo format

Progress Check 3

1i, 2h, 3g, 4f, 5e, 6d, 7c, 8b, 9a